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Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

1977 Pontiac Trans Am Restoration Guide

Model Year 1977

Model	Pontiac Firebird Trans Am (2nd-gen F-body)
Engines	400 cid Pontiac V8 (180 hp); W72 T/A 6.6 (200 hp); 403 cid Olds
Transmission	TH350 auto; Borg-Warner 4-speed (W72 only)
Production	68,745 Trans Ams; 15,567 Special Editions
Notable	The 'Bandit' year; Y81/Y82 black-and-gold SE

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

Published by RestorationEssentials

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Chapter 1 — The Second-Generation F-Body and the Bandit Year

The second-generation Firebird (1970½–81) was seven years old when 1977 gave it quad rectangular headlamps, a sharper nose, and the most famous film role any American car ever landed. Pontiac built 68,745 Trans Ams that year — more than the base, Esprit, and Formula lines' momentum combined suggested a few years earlier — and the black-and-gold Special Edition became, permanently, 'the Bandit car.' The 455 was gone; the 400 was the headline engine; and the restoration questions this guide answers are the ones the car still asks: which engine is really in it, is the gold factory, and where has the rust moved in.

Chapter 2 — What Makes 1977 Different

- **Restyle:** quad rectangular headlamps and the pointed 1977 nose — one-year look before the 1979 no-grille face.
- **No 455:** the big engine ended with 1976. A '77 wearing 455 badges is wearing a story, not an option.
- **W72:** the T/A 6.6 performance package — the only route to the Borg-Warner 4-speed.
- **Y81/Y82:** the Special Edition goes mainstream — 15,567 built per PMD records.

Chapter 3 — VIN and Fisher Body-Tag Decoding

The 13-character VIN opens with the division and series: **2** Pontiac, **W** Trans Am, **87** coupe. The engine letter follows — **Z** for the Pontiac 400, **K** for the Oldsmobile 403 in the standard decoder tables — then **7** for 1977, the assembly plant (**N** Norwood, Ohio; **L** Van Nuys, California), and the sequence. A documented example reads 2W87Z7N176876.



The Fisher body tag on the cowl carries the build detail: a documented decode reads ST77 (1977 style), 2FS87 (Pontiac Firebird coupe), the plant letter and Fisher body number, the trim code (19B = black cloth on the documented car), and A51 for bucket seats; the paint line carries the color code — 19, Starlight Black, on Special Edition cars. The recognized authority for proving a Y81/Y82 or W72 car is the Pontiac Historic Services documentation packet — order it before the restoration, not after the argument.

Chapter 4 — Engines: The 400, the T/A 6.6, and the 403

Three V8s wear '6.6' in 1977 documentation, and they are not interchangeable. The standard Trans Am engine is the Pontiac 400 (L78), 180 hp net with a four-barrel and dual exhaust. The T/A 6.6 (W72) is the same displacement at a hotter tune — 200 hp. California and high-altitude cars received the Oldsmobile-built 403 instead, an engine with its own parts universe and its own following; period references vary between 180 and 185 hp for it, and this guide says so rather than picking one silently. All three are documented in the service literature; none of them is a 455.

W72 specifics to preserve: its calibration, carburetion, and exhaust specification are the package as much as the sticker. A restoration that treats W72 as 'just a 400' erases the thing the buyer paid for in 1977.

Chapter 5 — Transmissions, Axles, and the W72 Driveline

The Turbo Hydra-Matic automatic serves the standard cars and the 403; the Borg-Warner 4-speed manual was rationed to the W72 package — 6,459 W72 cars were built across both transmissions, and the manual cars are the hunted ones. Axles are documented per car (a 3.23 limited-slip is documented on a Y82 example). Record the transmission and axle identification before removal; on W72 cars the driveline combination is part of the identity.

Chapter 6 — Suspension, Brakes, Steering, and the Snowflakes

Trans Am hardware was the handling flagship of the Firebird line: power front discs and rear drums, quick-ratio steering, and the model's own spring and bar calibration. Special Edition cars roll on 15-inch gold snowflake wheels — verify the casting and the gold tone against documented cars; snowflakes exist in several generations and only one belongs here. Tire size is a documented 225/70R15 in period fitments.

Chapter 7 — Special Editions: Y81, Y82, and the Gold Package

The black-and-gold Special Edition began as Pontiac's 50th-anniversary car for 1976 and became the Bandit for 1977. Two codes: **Y81**, the hardtop package at \$556, and **Y82**, the same car with Hurst T-top hatches at \$1,141. PMD records count 15,567 Special Editions for 1977. Equipment, in summary: gold snowflake wheels, gold pinstriping and lettering, the gold hood bird, gold engine-turned dash and console trim, and gold spokes on the Formula steering wheel.

Rarity math for restorers: roughly 6,000+ of the 15,567 were Y82 T-top cars (the figure 6,030 circulates for the automatic T-top subset; treat exact splits as PHS territory), and the W72-with-automatic SE subset is documented around 549 cars. Every SE carries a value premium and a clone industry — Chapter 16 handles the tells; the PHS packet settles them.

Chapter 8 — Paint, Stripes, and the Hood Bird

Special Edition paint is code 19, Starlight Black, with the gold graphics package; regular Trans Ams span the 1977 Pontiac chart, all on the cowl tag. The hood bird is a decal, not paint, and its placement and gold tone are restoration-grade details. The reproduction market is deep here — which means correctness is a research exercise, not a shopping exercise: match the documented package, not the loudest catalog photo.



Chapter 9 — Production Numbers and Rarity

1977 line	Built	Note
Trans Am (all)	68,745	PMD model-year total
Special Edition (Y81+Y82)	15,567	PMD records
W72 T/A 6.6 (all)	6,459	only route to 4-speed
Formula	21,801	for scale
Esprit / base	34,548 / 30,642	for scale

Context: Trans Am volume ran from about 47,000 in 1976 to more than 117,000 in 1979 — the Bandit effect is visible in the production curve itself.

Chapter 10 — Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide

Second-generation F-body rust has a map: rear frame rails where they kick over the axle, subframe mounting points (caged nuts spin and floors tear), floor pans, the trunk floor, lower rear quarters, and door bottoms. T-top cars add the roof openings, A-pillar bases, and the channels under the seals — Hurst panels on 1977 cars are famous leakers, so assume the structure has seen water and go look. Magnet, light, photographs, notes — before negotiation (Chapter 14).

Chapter 11 — Restoration Sequence for the 1977 Trans Am

- **1. Document** — VIN plate, cowl tag, engine stampings, transmission identification, photographs as found; order the PHS packet now.
- **2. Name the car honestly** — standard, W72, Y81, Y82, or a tribute. The PHS paperwork decides the budget's ceiling.
- **3. Structure first** — subframe mounts and rails before cosmetic metal; the car hangs off them.
- **4. Disassemble by system**; shaker, snowflakes, and SE graphics hardware tagged and stored together.
- **5. Drivetrain to its documented specification** — 400, W72, and 403 each restored as themselves.
- **6. Paint and graphics last**, to the cowl-tag code and the documented package.

Chapter 12 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Item	400 (L78)	T/A 6.6 (W72)	403 (Olds)
Rating	180 hp	200 hp	~180–185 hp
Where fitted	49-state standard	W72 package	CA / high-altitude
Carburetion	4-barrel	4-barrel, W72 tune	4-barrel
Manual trans	—	Borg-Warner 4-speed	—

Chapter 13 — Options and Factory Details

- W72 T/A 6.6 performance package (6,459 built) — includes the 200-hp tune; mandatory for the 4-speed.
- Y81 Special Edition hardtop (\$556); Y82 with Hurst T-tops (\$1,141).
- TH350 automatic on standard and 403 cars.



- Gold snowflake 15-inch wheels (SE); Trans Am suspension and quick steering standard.
- Hurst hatches were installed on hardtop shells — all Y82 cars began life with a roof, a fact that survives in the structure.

Chapter 14 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- PHS documentation ordered or in hand for any Y81/Y82/W72 claim — no packet, no premium.
- VIN engine letter read (Z = 400, K = 403) and matched to the engine actually in the car.
- Cowl tag photographed: paint, trim, build date against the VIN sequence.
- W72 cars: calibration and driveline components verified; 4-speed presence is necessary, not sufficient.
- T-top structure inspected with seals lifted; headliner and pillars checked for water history.
- Rear rails, subframe mounts, floors, and trunk mapped with photos.
- SE graphics and gold components matched to the documented package, not to a catalog cover.

Chapter 15 — Casting Numbers, Block Codes, and Date Codes

Pontiac blocks carry casting numbers and date codes, and the stamped engine code on the front of the block names the application. The flagship rule applies: castings precede the car's build and sit close to it, and the engine code must match the VIN letter's promise and the PHS paperwork. The 403 is an Oldsmobile engine with its own casting system — restore it as one, with Olds service literature, rather than forcing Pontiac expectations on it.

Chapter 16 — Clones and Conversions: Tells That Matter

Every piece of the Bandit look is reproducible in a weekend — black paint, gold decals, snowflakes — which is why the premium rides on paper: the PHS packet reading Y81 or Y82. Mechanical tells support the documents: W72 calibration parts, the correct shaker assembly for the engine fitted, Hurst-installed roof structure on Y82 cars. An honestly described tribute is a fun car at a tribute price; an undocumented 'Bandit' at an SE premium is the most common overpayment in this market.

Chapter 17 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

No torque value is printed that cannot be traced to factory service literature. The discipline stands: clean chased threads, lubrication as the manual specifies, the printed pattern in at least three steps, re-checks after the first heat cycle where the manual calls for them. Subframe and suspension hardware get factory values from the 1977 Pontiac service manual in Sources — on an F-body, the subframe bolts are structure. Record what you used.



Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- 1977 Pontiac Firebird factory service manual
- Pontiac 400 V8 engine rebuild kit
- 1970-1981 Firebird Trans Am restoration parts
- 1977 Pontiac Firebird parts catalog

As an Amazon Associate, RestorationEssentials earns from qualifying purchases made through these links.

Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:

- **Pontiac factory literature.** the 1977 Pontiac service manual and dealer ordering information — authority for torque values, specifications, and option definitions
- **PMD production records.** model-year and Special Edition counts as reported from Pontiac Motor Division records
- **Pontiac Historic Services.** the recognized documentation authority for Y81/Y82 and W72 verification
- **Publications International model histories.** 1977 Firebird line history, engine availability, and equipment summaries
- **Fisher body-tag documentation.** cowl-tag decode examples from documented cars (ST77, trim and paint codes)

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first 1977 Pontiac Trans Am or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

The year a movie turned a black Pontiac into an American folk hero. Restore the car the paperwork says you have — that's the one worth owning.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team